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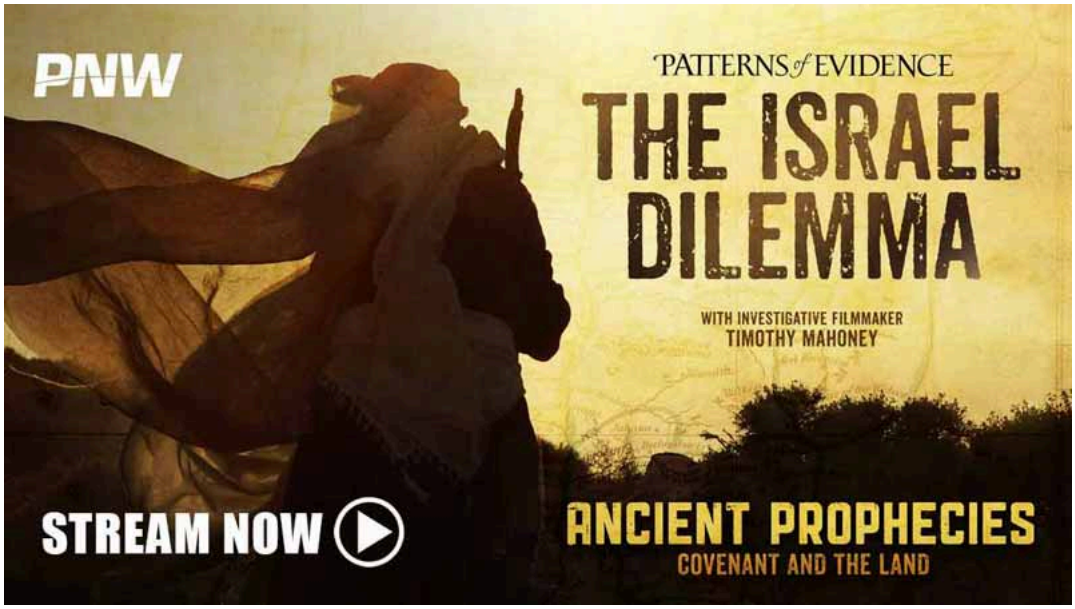

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ARTICLE

They're Not Watching You - They're Just Storing Everything About You

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Clearview fencing is designed to provide both security and visibility. Jumalu Fencing

BY PNW STAFF MARCH 17, 2026

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When governments build the infrastructure of control, history tells us exactly what happens next.

Imagine waking up tomorrow to learn that every company you do business with -- your phone carrier, your internet provider, your GPS app -- has been legally required to store a detailed record of your movements, your devices, and your daily patterns for the past year. Not because you're suspected of anything. Not because a judge reviewed your case. Simply because you exist, and the government decided your data might be useful someday.

That is not a dystopian thought experiment. That is Canada, today.

Bill C-22, the Lawful Access Act, 2026, compels every electronic service provider in the country to warehouse the metadata of every Canadian citizen -- location data, device identifiers, transmission records -- for twelve months, pre-packaged and ready for law enforcement retrieval. The government's own description of its logic is almost admirably candid: build the haystack first, search it later. Every Canadian becomes a potential suspect before a single crime is committed.

Tai Chi Exercises For Elderly

Public Safety Minister Gary Anandasangaree assures Canadians there's nothing to worry about. "It is not about surveillance of Canadians going on about their daily lives," he said at the bill's introduction. It is a line as old as the surveillance state itself. Every government that has ever constructed a mass monitoring apparatus has said essentially the same thing. They always mean it -- at first.

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The cybersecurity implications are just as troubling as the civil liberties ones. Privacy advocates have warned that forcing companies to engineer surveillance access into their own networks is an invitation to disaster. Once a backdoor is built into a system, it doesn't stay exclusive to its original architects. Every intelligence adversary, every criminal hacker, every foreign state actor now has a target to aim for. The government has essentially legislated a vulnerability into the foundations of Canadian digital infrastructure and called it a safety measure.

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Location data alone -- where you sleep, where you worship, which clinic you visit, which rally you attend -- assembled over the course of a year, tells a more intimate story about a person than most diaries ever could. Multiply that by 40 million Canadians and you have something that has never existed before in this country: a comprehensive, government-mandated portrait of an entire population, pre-assembled, pre-stored, and waiting.

Americans watching from across the border should resist the urge to feel comfortable. The United States already operates one of the most expansive surveillance programs in the democratic world. Under Section 702 of the Foreign Intelligence Surveillance Act, the government can collect and search the electronic communications of American citizens without a warrant. FBI searches of this data rose 35% in a single year. The haystack already exists -- and it is growing.

The pattern is consistent across history. FISA itself was born from the surveillance abuses of the Nixon administration -- a law designed to contain government overreach that later became the legal cover for it. The post-9/11 era produced the NSA's mass domestic wiretapping program, operated in secret for years under a creative reinterpretation of laws that were never meant to permit it. Extraordinary powers, once granted, do not shrink. They normalize.

The most instructive parallel, however, is not historical. It is current and ongoing. China's surveillance state was not assembled in a single authoritarian stroke. It was constructed incrementally, provision by provision, system by system -- each justified with the familiar language of public safety, social stability, and national security.

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Canada is not China. But Canada is now building the same kind of infrastructure on the same foundational logic: that the state's need to know supersedes the citizen's right to live unobserved. The gap between a democratic surveillance apparatus and an authoritarian one is not a wall. It is a change in government.

Ask yourself the question that never gets asked loudly enough: what will those in power do with this system when they encounter people they don't like? History does not offer reassuring answers. Governments with the tools to monitor dissent have always, eventually, used those tools against it.

Democracies do not fall in a single dramatic moment. They erode through a long sequence of reasonable-sounding decisions -- each one a small concession, each one justified by safety, each one making the next concession easier. Bill C-22 is one of those decisions.

Once the haystack is built, it never gets smaller. And once the government decides to look for you in it, there will be nowhere left to hide.

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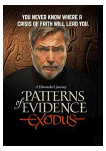

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